ANCHOR SILVER CAPITAL



INVESTOR EDUCATION SERIES · RETIREMENT ACCOUNTS

The Precious Metals IRA Handbook

Moving retirement savings into real gold and silver.

Done as a direct transfer: generally without tax, without penalty, without guesswork.

anchorsilvercapital.com · (866) 818-7243 · Marina del Rey, CA

For educational purposes only. Not investment or tax advice. Past performance does not guarantee future results.

Important Disclosures

Purpose

This handbook has been prepared by Anchor Silver Capital for educational purposes only. It explains how a self-directed precious metals retirement account, holding gold, silver, or both, works. It is not investment advice, not tax advice, and not a solicitation or offer to buy or sell any security or precious metal.

We are not tax advisors

Retirement account rules are set by the Internal Revenue Code and administered by the IRS. They are detailed, they contain exceptions, and they change. Everything in this guide is general information. Before you move retirement money anywhere, confirm the treatment of your specific situation with a qualified tax professional. We will say this more than once, because it matters more than anything else in these pages.

Not investment advice

Anchor Silver Capital is a precious metals dealer registered in the State of California. We are not a registered investment advisor, broker-dealer, financial planner, or insurance professional. Nothing here is personalized advice about whether precious metals belong in your retirement portfolio, in what proportion, or how to divide them between gold and silver.

Risk

Gold and silver are volatile and pay no interest or dividends. Their prices can decline substantially. A retirement account holding physical metal is exposed to that risk in full. You may lose money.

Independent parties

American Estate & Trust (AET) is an independent IRA custodian. International Depository Services (IDS) of Delaware is an independent storage facility. Neither is affiliated with, owned by, or controlled by Anchor Silver Capital. We do not receive compensation from either for referring you.

Sources

Rules described here derive from the Internal Revenue Code, principally sections 408 and 408(m), and from IRS Publications 590-A and 590-B. Where a threshold or dollar figure is cited, it reflects published guidance at the time of writing and is subject to annual adjustment.

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Contents

01 What a precious metals IRA actually is 4

02 Whether you qualify 6

03 Transfer or rollover: the distinction that matters 7

04 What the IRS permits you to hold 9

05 Gold, silver, or both 12

06 The custodian, the depository, and the dealer 13

07 Fees, stated plainly 15

08 Taking money out 16

09 Nine mistakes that cost people money 17

10 How to begin 18

The short version.

You can move money from an existing retirement account into a self-directed IRA that holds physical gold, silver, or both. Done as a direct trustee-to-trustee transfer, there is generally no tax and no penalty. The metal must meet a minimum fineness and must be stored at an approved depository rather than at your home. That is the whole thing. Everything else in this handbook is detail.



CHAPTER 1 · THE BASICS

What a Precious Metals IRA Is

A precious metals IRA is not a special kind of retirement account. It is an ordinary IRA with an unusual asset inside it.

That distinction matters, because a great deal of confusing marketing implies otherwise. There is no separate section of the tax code creating a “Gold IRA” or a “Silver IRA.” There is simply an Individual Retirement Account, governed by the same rules as any other, which happens to hold gold and silver bullion instead of mutual funds.

SAME ACCOUNT, DIFFERENT CONTENTS

	Standard IRA	Precious metals IRA
Contribution limits	✓ Same	✓ Same
Distribution rules	✓ Same	✓ Same
Tax treatment	✓ Same	✓ Same
What it holds	Funds, stocks, bonds	**Physical gold and silver bullion**
Who holds the account	Brokerage	**Self-directed custodian**
Where the asset sits	Electronic record	**Approved depository**

A Traditional gold or silver IRA is taxed like any Traditional IRA. A Roth gold or silver IRA is taxed like any Roth.

The only three real differences

1

A self-directed custodian

Most brokerages will not hold physical metal, so the account sits with a custodian that specializes in alternative assets.

2

An approved depository

The metal must be stored at an IRS-approved facility. You cannot keep it at home while it is inside the IRA.

3

A fineness standard

The tax code sets a minimum purity. Metal that falls short is not merely disallowed: buying it is treated as a distribution.

Why “self-directed” appears everywhere

A conventional IRA at a large brokerage offers a menu: their funds, their equities, their bonds. A self-directed IRA reverses that arrangement. The custodian holds the account and handles the reporting, but you decide what it buys. That is what makes physical metal possible, and it is also what makes the custodian’s role narrower than people expect.

A self-directed custodian does not evaluate your investment. It does not advise you, vet the dealer, or judge whether the price is fair. It processes your instruction and keeps the records straight.

Worth remembering.

Any custodian claiming to endorse a particular dealer or product should be treated with suspicion, because that is not what a custodian does.

Whether You Qualify

Almost anyone with an existing retirement account can move some or all of it into physical metal. The constraint is rarely eligibility. It is access: whether the money is currently locked inside a plan run by an employer you still work for.

Where the money is now	Can it move?	What to know
401(k) from a former employer	Yes, at any age	The most common source. No age restriction once you have left the employer.
Traditional IRA	Yes, at any age	Usually the simplest and fastest route. A direct transfer between custodians.
Roth IRA	Yes, at any age	Moves to a Roth self-directed IRA and keeps its Roth character.
403(b), 457(b), or TSP	Usually, if separated	Government, nonprofit, federal, and military plans. Your administrator will confirm.
Annuity	Often, at any age	Depends on the contract. Surrender charges may apply, so read them first.
401(k) with a current employer	Generally only at 59½+	Called an in-service distribution. Not every plan permits it.

General practice, not a ruling on your account. Plan documents govern and they differ. SEP and SIMPLE IRAs also qualify, though SIMPLE plans carry a two-year holding rule. One call to your administrator settles it.

A WORD ABOUT PARTIAL MOVES

You are not required to move everything, and most people do not. A partial transfer leaves your existing account open and moves only the portion you want in metal. Any proportion is permitted.



Illustration only. The split is yours to decide.

On how much.

We are not licensed to tell you what percentage of your retirement savings belongs in precious metals. Most people treat it as one component of a broader portfolio rather than a replacement for it, and anyone urging you to move an entire balance into any single asset, metal included, is not acting in your interest.

Transfer or Rollover

These two words are used interchangeably in conversation and in most advertising. They are not the same thing, and the difference has real tax consequences. This is the single most important chapter in this handbook.

THE SAFE ROUTE

Direct transfer

Old custodian — New custodian

- The money never touches your hands
- Not treated as a distribution
- No deadline, no withholding, no limit

THE ROUTE WITH TRAPS

Indirect rollover

Old plan — You (a check) — New custodian

- A 60-day clock starts on the check
- Employer plans withhold 20%
- One IRA rollover per 12 months

Feature	Direct transfer	Indirect rollover
Tax withheld	None	20% from employer plans
Deadline to complete	None. No clock runs.	60 calendar days
Frequency limit	Unlimited	One IRA-to-IRA rollover per 12 months
Risk of accidental taxation	Effectively nil	Real, and common

The indirect rollover, step by step

In an indirect rollover, the plan pays you. A check arrives. You then have sixty calendar days to deposit that money into the receiving account. Miss the deadline and the entire amount becomes a taxable distribution, plus a ten percent penalty if you are under 59½.

There is a second trap. When an employer plan makes a distribution payable to you, it is generally required to withhold twenty percent for federal tax. To complete a full rollover, you must make up that twenty percent out of your own pocket and reclaim it when you file.

The 20% withholding trap

Illustration: a hypothetical $100,000 distribution from an employer plan.



The one-per-twelve-months rule.

You may complete only one indirect IRA-to-IRA rollover in any rolling twelve-month period, across all your IRAs combined. It is not a calendar-year rule and it is not per account. Direct transfers are exempt from it entirely.

Our standing recommendation.

Use a direct trustee-to-trustee transfer unless there is a specific reason not to. It has no deadline, no withholding, no frequency limit, and almost no way to go wrong. In the great majority of cases where someone has been taxed unexpectedly on a retirement move, an indirect rollover was involved.



CHAPTER 4 · ELIGIBLE METAL

What the IRS Permits You to Hold

The tax code generally bars retirement accounts from holding collectibles. Precious metals were carved out as a narrow exception: the metal must meet a minimum fineness and be held by the trustee rather than by you.

MINIMUM FINENESS

SILVER

.999

The standard for every silver product in this handbook.

GOLD

.995

The American Gold Eagle qualifies despite lower fineness.

PLATINUM

.9995

Eligible, but outside the scope of this handbook.

PALLADIUM

.9995

Eligible, but outside the scope of this handbook.

Fineness thresholds are set by the Internal Revenue Code. Metal that falls short is not merely unavailable: purchasing it inside an IRA is treated as a distribution, with tax and possibly penalty attached.

SILVER PRODUCTS THAT GENERALLY QUALIFY

American Silver Eagle — *.999*

The most widely recognized US silver coin. Carries a higher premium.

Canadian Silver Maple Leaf — *.9999*

Higher fineness, generally a lower premium than the Eagle.

Australian Silver Kangaroo — *.9999*

Government issued, with strong international recognition.

Approved refiner bars — *.999*

From refiners accredited by recognized exchanges. Best value at size.

GOLD PRODUCTS THAT GENERALLY QUALIFY

American Gold Eagle *.9167*

Qualifies by statute despite its lower fineness. The most widely recognized US gold coin, and it carries a higher premium.

American Gold Buffalo *.9999*

US Mint 24-karat coin. Higher fineness than the Eagle, and generally a lower premium.

Canadian Gold Maple Leaf *.9999*

Government issued and widely traded, with strong international recognition.

Approved refiner bars *.995*

From refiners accredited by recognized exchanges. Best value at size.

What does not qualify

Numismatic and collectible coins are the recurring problem. Rare-date coins, graded coins in slabs, pre-1933 US gold coins, and pre-1965 US 90% silver coins are generally not permitted inside a retirement account, however they are marketed.

Proof coins are a special case. Some, including proof American Eagles, are permitted, but they typically carry premiums far above their metal content.



A Morgan silver dollar: 90% silver and priced as a collectible. It does not qualify.

This is not a technicality to be negotiated around. If an IRA buys metal that does not meet the standard, the purchase is treated as a distribution of that amount: taxable, and subject to penalty if you are under 59½. The consequence falls on you, not on the dealer who sold it.

A warning worth taking seriously.

Regulators have brought substantial enforcement actions against firms that sold heavily marked-up “IRA-approved” collectible coins to retirement savers. If a dealer steers you from ordinary bullion toward a special coin carrying a premium many times the metal content, end the conversation. Ask what it costs as a percentage over spot. A straight answer is the minimum you should accept.

HOW TO CHECK A PRODUCT YOURSELF

1 Read the fineness

Every bullion coin and bar has its purity stamped on the face. Silver must read .999 or better. Gold bars must read .995 or better.

2 Bullion or not?

Bullion is priced from metal content. Numismatics are priced from rarity. Only bullion belongs in an IRA.

3 Compare to spot

Divide the quoted price per ounce by the spot price. A modest premium is normal. A multiple is not.

Questions to ask about any product

Before you approve a purchase, you should be able to get a plain, written answer to each of these from anyone selling metal for your IRA.

- What exactly is the product, and what is its stamped fineness?
- Is it bullion, or is it priced for rarity or condition?
- What is the spot price right now, and what am I paying per ounce, all in?
- What is the difference between those two numbers, as a percentage?
- Will every one of these figures be in writing before I approve?



CHAPTER 5 · TWO METALS

Gold, Silver, or Both

Both metals are eligible, and many people hold both. They behave differently, and the differences are practical ones worth understanding before you decide.

	Gold	Silver
Price per ounce	Much higher. A given dollar amount buys fewer ounces.	Much lower. The same dollar amount buys many more ounces.
Where demand comes from	Investment, jewelry, and central bank reserves.	Investment, plus a large industrial share, including electronics and solar.
Price swings	Has historically been less volatile.	Has historically been more volatile.
Dealer premium over spot	Generally a lower percentage on bars at size.	Generally a higher percentage, because handling costs are spread over a lower-priced ounce.
Physical size per dollar	Compact.	Bulkier. Ask your custodian how storage is priced.
IRA fineness standard	.995 minimum, with the American Gold Eagle as an exception.	.999 minimum.

General characteristics, not predictions. Neither metal pays interest or dividends, and either can decline in value.

WHAT PEOPLE TEND TO WEIGH

Reasons people choose gold

- A long record as a store of value across centuries.
- Held in reserve by central banks around the world.
- A smaller footprint for the same dollar value.

Reasons people choose silver

- A lower price per ounce, so a given amount buys more of it.
- Industrial uses in addition to its monetary history.
- More flexibility in how much you buy at a time.

On how much of each.

We are not licensed to tell you what mix of gold and silver belongs in your account, or whether either belongs there at all. Choose the mix that fits your own goals, with your tax and financial professionals.

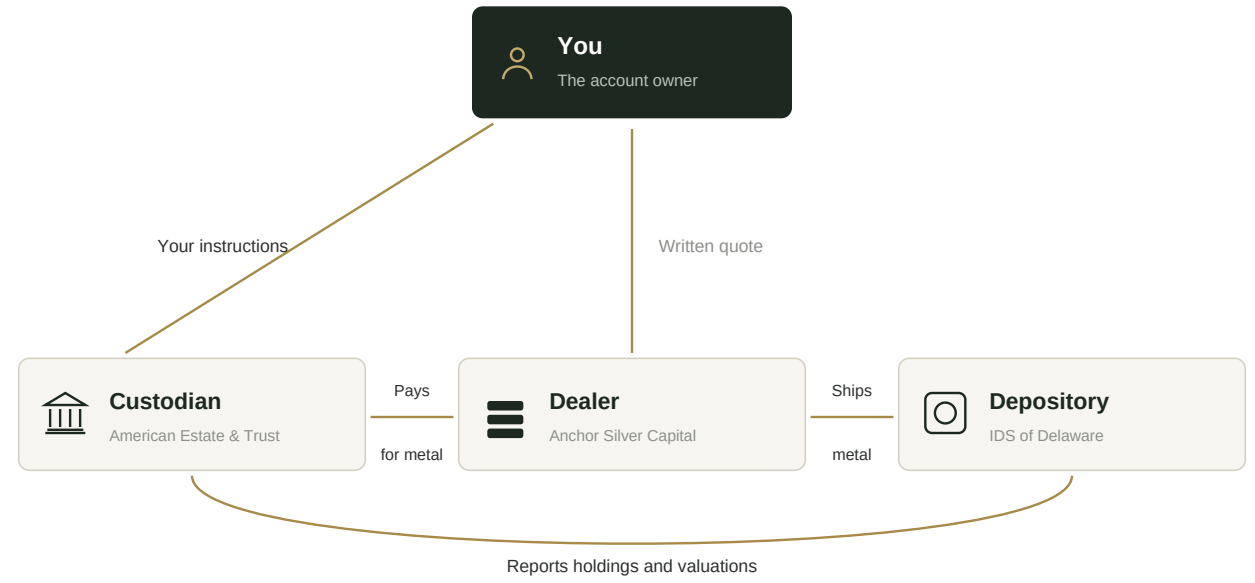


CHAPTER 6 · WHO DOES WHAT

Custodian, Depository, Dealer

Three separate parties are involved in every precious metals IRA, and they do genuinely different jobs. Confusing them is how people end up in trouble, so it is worth being precise.

HOW THE PIECES CONNECT



The separation is deliberate and protective. No single party controls both the asset and the record of it.

The custodian

American Estate & Trust

DOES

Holds the account. Processes your instructions. Files the IRS reporting. Coordinates transfers with your old provider.

DOES NOT

Give advice. Recommend a dealer. Vet the price. Store the metal.

The depository

IDS of Delaware

DOES

Receives, verifies, and stores the metal. Insures it. Reports holdings and valuations to the custodian.

DOES NOT

Sell you anything. Advise you. Release metal to you directly.

The dealer

Anchor Silver Capital

DOES

Sources the metal, quotes the price, and ships it to the depository in your name. Explains the process.

DOES NOT

Hold your account. Store your metal. Give tax or investment advice.

Why you cannot store it at home

The tax code requires that metal held in a retirement account be in the physical possession of the trustee. Structures marketed as “home storage IRAs” or “checkbook LLC IRAs” try to route around this by having the IRA own a company that holds the metal in your house. The Tax Court has ruled against a taxpayer using precisely that arrangement, treating the metal as a taxable distribution in the year it was received. No workaround exists in any form we would put our name to.

Metal in your hands

Buy it outside a retirement account

- Entirely legal and straightforward
- Shipped to you
- No IRA tax advantages

or

Metal in your IRA

Held at an approved depository

- Tax advantages of the IRA
- Insured, audited storage
- Never kept at home

TWO WAYS A DEPOSITORY CAN HOLD YOUR METAL

Commingled storage

Your metal is held alongside identical products owned by other investors. You own a specific quantity of a specific product, and get the same product back.

Segregated storage

Your specific bars and coins are stored separately and labeled to your account. It usually costs more. Ask your custodian which options apply.

Fees, Stated Plainly

There are four costs in a precious metals IRA. Any dealer unwilling to itemize all four in writing before you commit is telling you something important about themselves.

Account setup

THE CUSTODIAN

One-time, when the account is opened.

Annual custodian fee

THE CUSTODIAN

Yearly, for administration and IRS reporting.

Storage and insurance

THE DEPOSITORY

Annual, usually based on the value of the metal, with a minimum.

Dealer premium

THE DEALER

The amount above spot you pay for the metal. Varies by product and order size.

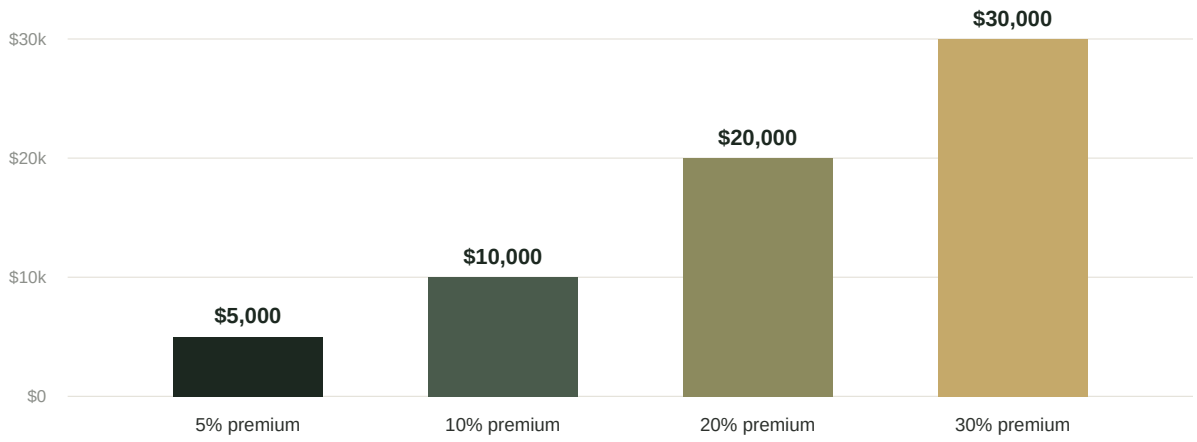
Custodian and depository schedules are published by those firms and are subject to change. Ask for the current schedule in writing. Both will provide it.

The one that actually moves the needle

Custodian and storage fees are modest, published, and broadly similar across reputable providers. The dealer premium is where money is made or lost. It varies enormously, from a few percent on large bars to a great deal more on coins sold as special or exclusive.

What the premium costs on a $100,000 purchase

Simple arithmetic, for illustration. Not a quote or a typical rate.



Taking Money Out

Distributions from a precious metals IRA work the same way as any other IRA, with one practical wrinkle: the account holds metal rather than cash, so something has to be sold or shipped.

Cash distribution

The custodian sells enough metal and sends you the proceeds.

A few business days to settle.

In-kind distribution

The metal itself is shipped to you, reported at fair market value.

Same tax treatment as cash.

THE AGES THAT MATTER

Before 59½

Traditional: taxed as income, plus a 10% penalty unless an exception applies.

59½

The penalty no longer applies. Traditional distributions remain taxable as income.

73 or 75

Required minimum distributions begin at 73 (born 1951-1959) or 75 (born 1960 or later).

Roth accounts. Qualified Roth distributions are generally tax-free, and Roth IRAs carry no required minimum distributions during the owner's lifetime.

A planning point people miss.

If your whole retirement balance sits in metal and you reach required-distribution age, every annual withdrawal forces a sale, whatever the price happens to be that year. Holding liquidity elsewhere avoids being a forced seller at an awkward moment. Put this to a tax professional well before you need the answer.

Nine Costly Mistakes

Every one of these has happened to someone. Most are avoidable in a single phone call.

1

Taking an indirect rollover

Adds a 60-day deadline and 20% withholding for no benefit. Ask for a direct transfer by name.

2

Buying collectibles in the IRA

Metal that fails the fineness test is treated as a distribution. Marketing does not override the tax code.

3

Paying an undisclosed premium

Get the spot price, the all-in price, and the difference as a percentage, in writing, before you commit.

4

Attempting home storage

The Tax Court has ruled against it. There is no compliant version marketed as a workaround.

5

Missing the 60-day window

If a rollover is unavoidable, calendar the deadline the day the check is issued, not the day it arrives.

6

A second rollover in 12 months

The limit covers all your IRAs combined, on a rolling basis, not per calendar year.

7

Moving everything into one asset

No responsible dealer should encourage this. Concentration risk does not vanish because metal is tangible.

8

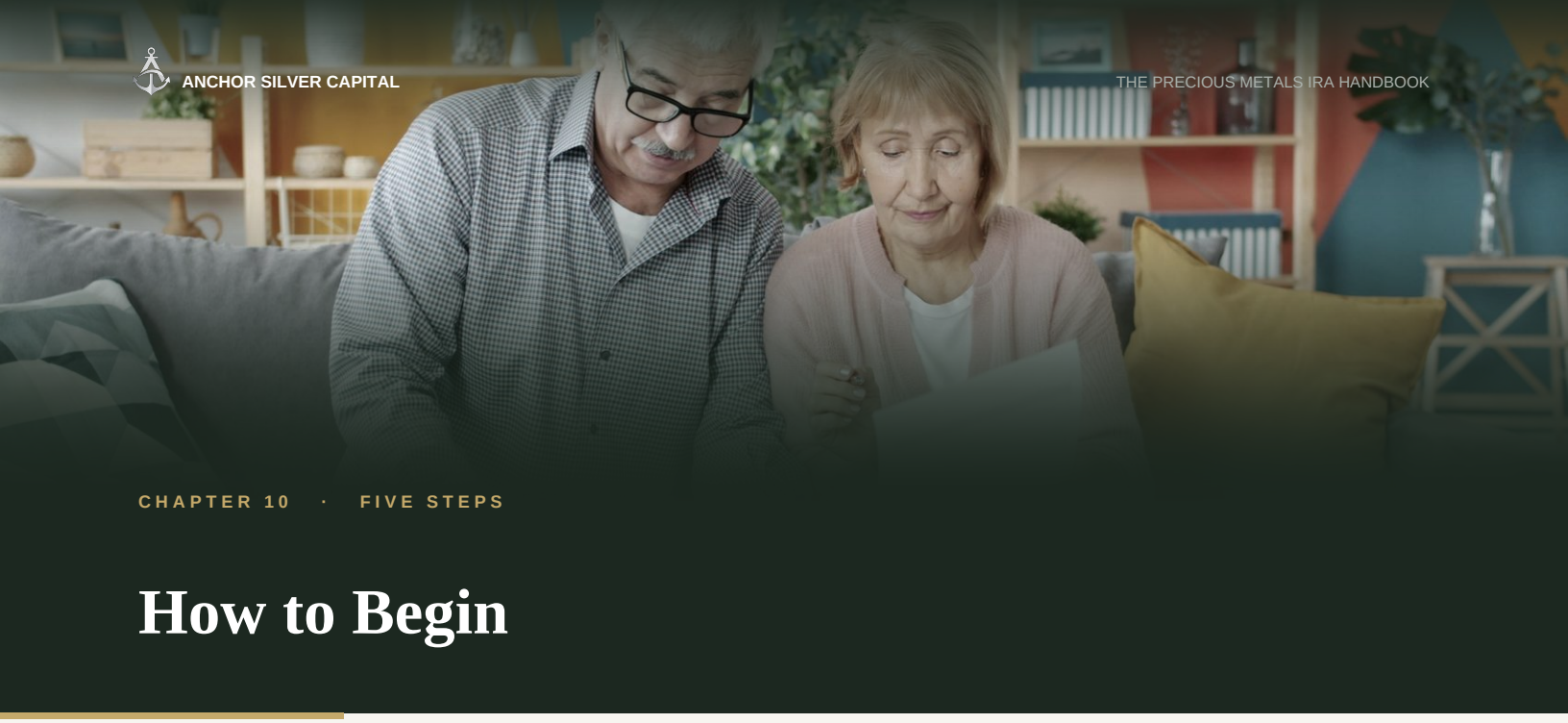
Forgetting required distributions

At required-distribution age, an all-metal account with no liquidity plan means selling on a schedule set by someone else.

9

A dealer who won’t put it in writing

Every figure that matters should be on paper before money moves. If it is not, that is the answer.



CHAPTER 10 · FIVE STEPS

How to Begin

There is no form to complete before you can speak to someone, and no obligation attached to the conversation.

1. **Find out what you have**
   Call your current plan administrator and ask two things: the current balance, and whether a direct trustee-to-trustee transfer is available.

2. **A short conversation with us**
   Ten to fifteen minutes. We ask where the money sits and what you are trying to protect, then tell you honestly whether this fits.

3. **Open the self-directed account**
   An application with American Estate & Trust. Your specialist stays on the line and walks you through each field.

4. **The transfer runs in the background**
   The custodian contacts your existing provider and coordinates the move, typically two to three weeks. You just receive updates.

5. **Choose the metal and secure it**
   You receive a written proposal: products, quantities, all-in cost. On approval, the custodian buys and we ship to the depository in your name.

Before you call anyone, including us, speak to a tax professional about your circumstances. Your situation is specific; ours is general. Half an hour with an accountant before you move retirement money is the cheapest insurance available.



Questions About Any of This?

We don’t sell over email and we won’t pressure you on the phone. If you want to talk through whether a precious metals IRA makes sense for your situation, or just have questions about anything in this handbook, we’re easy to reach.

(866) 818-7243

info@anchorsilvercapital.com
anchorsilvercapital.com
475 Washington Blvd, Marina del Rey, CA 90292
Monday to Friday, 8:00am to 6:00pm Pacific
Office visits by appointment only

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